

Sir Syed Ahmad Khan, knighted in 1888 for services to the Government of India, which allowed his critics to brand him a tool of the British.

With the formation of these three institutions – Aligarh College, Dar-ul-Ulum Deoband and Ahl-i-Hadith – a struggle began for the hearts and minds of India's Muslims, one in which the modernisers proved unable to match the appeal of the traditionalists and separatists. But the latter did not have it all their own way. In the 1890s a fourth institution entered the debate, founded by a Hanafi cleric named Ahmed Reza Khan Barelvi in response to Ahl-i-Hadith and Deobandi attacks on the popular practice of venerating the shrines of saints and praying for their intercession. This quasi-Sufi movement became known as Barelvi Islam and became hugely popular throughout the subcontinent, so